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SATIPANYA BUDDHIST RETREAT

# Guided Meditations

*Guided vipassanā meditation practices and Pāli chanting*

**Bhante Bodhidhamma**

SHROPSHIRE, WALES · UNITED KINGDOM

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# Introducing Vipassanā Insight Meditation

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 39 min

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*This introductory guided meditation offers a comprehensive foundation in vipassanā (insight meditation) practice according to the Mahāsi Sayadaw tradition. Bhante Bodhidhamma guides practitioners through the essential elements of noting practice, beginning with establishing awareness of rising and falling breath sensations at the abdomen using simple noting words.*

*The session systematically introduces key aspects of vipassanā: maintaining upright posture, dealing skillfully with wandering mind through gentle acknowledgment, and expanding awareness to include sounds, bodily sensations, and mental states as they arise. Practitioners learn to note experiences such as "thinking," "hearing," "pain," or emotional states like "anxiety" and "excitement," observing how all phenomena arise and pass away naturally.*

*The meditation culminates in recognizing the three characteristics (tilakkhana) of existence: impermanence (anicca), unsatisfactoriness (dukkha), and not-self (anattā). Bhante emphasizes developing the capacity to observe the distinction between the knower and what is known, fostering the clear comprehension essential to insight practice. The session concludes with guidance for reflective review, encouraging practitioners to assess their diligence, skillfulness, and awareness of the fundamental characteristics of experience.*

Make sure you're sitting comfortably and upright. Lift up through the top of the head. Natural curvature in the spine. Shoulders relaxed. Jaw relaxed. Lips together, teeth apart. Eyes gently closed. And hands on the lap, palms facing upward. Probably the most comfortable.

Now placing the attention on the abdomen. Just feeling the rising and falling sensations caused by the breath. Get in touch with those sensations. What do they feel like? And use the noting word rising, falling to keep the thinking mind from wandering. And just notice whether it's a long breath or a short breath, tight, relaxed and so on.

If the mind is wandering, recognise and acknowledge what it's doing. Thinking, thinking, worrying, worrying, dreaming, dreaming and so on. And then bring the attention back to the breath.

As we settle down, we may find there's a gap at the end of the out-breath before the in-breath begins again. Using the noting word touching, find a sensation you can feel, such as the touch of your hands. So now relax and attend to the sensations caused by the breath. Rising, falling, touching.

If the mind is wandering, recognise and acknowledge what it's doing. Thinking, thinking, worrying, worrying, dreaming, dreaming, and so on, and bring that attention back to the abdomen.

You may also begin to feel sleepy or lethargic, in which case sit upright, lift the body up through the top of the head. And if that's not enough, open the eyes a little to let the light in. But don't look around. And if that's not enough to keep us awake, you can stand up. We can practice *vipassanā* standing up just as well.

Now begin to feel the sensations caused by the breath as neutral and pleasant. Pleasant, neutral sensations, relaxing the body, calming the heart, silencing the mind. Rising, falling, touching.

We can gently focus in and notice the very start of the in-breath and the very end. The very beginning of the out-breath and the very end. Rising, falling, touching.

When we feel somewhat settled on the breath, we can allow whatever draws our attention to be felt and observed in the same way. Should a sound draw us, we are interested in the process of hearing. Noting hearing, hearing. Should a feeling arise in the body, pleasant or unpleasant, note it. Pain, pain. Aching, aching. Tickling, tickling. Anxiety, anxiety. Excitement, excitement. And just as with the breath, observe it, feel it, experience it fully.

And don't forget, if we find the mind wandering, just note what it's doing and start again with the breath. The breath is our reference point and anchor. It's where we always start again. Rising, falling, touching.

Noting, feeling, observing anything that draws our attention. Can you see how everything we are experiencing is arising and passing away?

Can you note your reaction to what you're experiencing? If it is unpleasant, aversion, aversion, fear, fear. If it's pleasant, desiring, desiring, wanting, wanting.

Noting, feeling, observing anything that draws our attention, can we see that everything is arising of its own accord, not under our control? Sensations, feelings, emotions and moods arise and pass away whether we want them to or not. Thoughts and imagining draw us away whether we want to go away or not.

Noting, feeling, observing anything that draws our attention, can we sense the distance, a separation, between the observer, the feeler, the knower, the experiencer, and what it is that's being experienced?

So, putting aside all instructions, all thoughts, let's just note, observe, feel, experience anything that draws our attention within the field of awareness. Begin with the breath. Rising, falling, touching.

When we come to the end of a sitting, we can reflect on three things. How diligent was I in bringing myself back into the presenting moment? How did I deal with the various bodily and mental states that arose? Was I skillful or unskillful? Was I confused? Was I aware of one or all of the three characteristics at any time? Impermanence, unsatisfactoriness and not-self.

Can we now make a resolution for the next sitting?

## Vipassanā Guidelines

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 3 min

*Bhante Bodhidhamma provides comprehensive guidelines for vipassanā insight meditation practice. Beginning with proper posture—an energized spine, relaxed body, and poised head—the instructions focus on observing abdominal sensations during natural breathing, using simple noting words like 'rising' and 'falling' to anchor attention.*

*As stability develops, practitioners learn to extend awareness to whatever arises—sensations, feelings, emotions, thoughts, and mental images—observing each phenomenon with bare attention and noting words. This choiceless awareness, free from control or judgment, cultivates satipaṇṇā (right awareness with intuitive intelligence).*

*The talk explains how this impartial observation leads to direct insight into the three characteristics of existence: anicca (impermanence), dukkha (unsatisfactoriness), and anattā (not-self). Through intimate experience of these universal truths, practitioners realize that identification with or attachment to any phenomenon brings dissatisfaction. This vipassanā insight ultimately leads to complete liberation from suffering and the realization of Nibbāna—described as the unborn, unbecome, undying, uncreated, and unconditioned. The instruction concludes with the profound teaching that 'those who are mindful are in the presence of Nibbāna.'*

Whatever the sitting posture, it should be comfortable and fulfil three conditions. An energised spine with its natural curvature, the rest of the body relaxed and the head poised on top. The hands are placed on the lap and the eyes are gently closed.

Then the attention is fixed on the process of breathing, just the normal and natural breath. It is the sensations of the abdomen caused by breathing which are to be observed. And a noting word is used to focus the thinking mind onto these sensations. As the abdomen rises, the word "rising" is repeated. As it falls, "falling."

Feeling the sensations of the abdomen as neutral and pleasant, the heart is calmed and the mind is stilled. Then the beginning and end of each in-breath and out-breath are more clearly seen.

When the attention becomes somewhat steady, let it experience whatever draws it within the field of awareness: sensations and feelings, moods and emotions, mental images and thoughts. Using a simple word to note and without any interference whatsoever, all these passing phenomena are to be intimately felt and carefully observed.

Should the mind wander, let it be brought back gently but firmly to observe sensations at the abdomen in order to cultivate a sharp attentiveness. In this way, right awareness with intuitive intelligence, *satipaṇṇā*, becomes established.

This bare attentiveness, simply watching all that arises and passes away, this choiceless awareness that does not control or manipulate, this impartial observation that does not judge or question, this intuitive introspection, fully experiencing each physical, emotional and mental event as it really is, leads to the realisation that everything is impermanent and insubstantial and that to identify with or to become attached to anything whatsoever will bring dissatisfaction.

These *vipassanā* insights into the three characteristics of existence—impermanence, unsatisfactoriness and not-self, *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anattā*—lead to the complete liberation from all suffering, the experience of the unborn, the unbecome, the undying, the uncreated, the unconditioned: true refuge, harbour and home, perfect happiness and contentment.

Those who are mindful are in the presence of *Nibbāna*.

*Sādhū. Sādhū. Sādhū.*

## 45 Minute Detailed Guided Meditation

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 45 min

*This guided meditation provides detailed instructions for practicing vipassanā bhāvanā (insight meditation) according to the Mahasi Sayadaw tradition of Burma. Bhante Bodhidhamma guides practitioners through the complete process, beginning with establishing proper meditative posture and deep relaxation techniques.*

*The session covers the fundamental elements of the practice: using the breath at the abdomen as the primary meditation object, employing noting techniques ("rising, falling, touching") to maintain concentrated awareness, and skillfully working with wandering thoughts and physical sensations. The guidance extends beyond basic concentration to the heart of insight practice—developing satipaṇṇā (mindful awareness) that observes all arising mental and physical phenomena without attachment or aversion.*

*Bhante explains how to work with challenging experiences like pain, emotions, and restlessness as opportunities for deeper understanding. The meditation culminates in pointing toward the three characteristics of existence: impermanence (anicca), not-self (anattā), and unsatisfactoriness (dukkha). This practice develops the choiceless awareness that leads to liberation from suffering and the realization of nibbāna.*

*Suitable for both beginners seeking comprehensive instruction and experienced practitioners wanting to deepen their understanding of traditional vipassanā technique.*

A Detailed Guided Meditation Instructions on how to practice *Vipassanā Bhāvanā* insight meditation as taught by the Mahāsi Sayadaw of Burma.

Firstly, we must settle our body into a meditative posture. Some sit on chairs, others use kneeling stools, but the usual position is to sit on the floor with a cushion in a cross-legged posture. Your hands should rest on your lap, preferably one on top of the other.

Now whatever posture you adopt it should at first feel comfortable. Then make sure the spine is straight though keeping its natural curvature. It's best not to lean against anything for this will induce sleep.

Now imagine a puppet string running from the base of the spine to the top of the head and it being gently pulled up so that all the vertebrae separate and there's a feeling of growing tall and light. A feeling of energy running up the spine without any tension or tightness. And the head should feel balanced on top.



Now just let everything relax off that central column. Here we can help ourselves relax with some simple exercises.

Firstly, let's see how relaxed we can become by simply telling muscles to relax. Start from the top of the head and go down the rest of the body relaxing muscles as best you can. So start at the top of the head, come down over the brow, the eyes, the cheeks, the jaw, especially the jaw, the neck, shoulders, arms, and hands. Just feel everything getting heavier as tension stops supporting them. Now go back to the chest. Relax it. Go down the body to the stomach, to the abdomen. Just relaxing as best as you can. And finally, just feel your legs heavy on the floor.

Superficial surface tension should now be released if only a little, but we may feel a deeper level of tension more habitual and therefore not easy to relax by a mental volition. We can use a second technique here of muscular tension. Where you feel tension tense the muscles in that area as hard as you can and release them slowly. This is especially good for tension in the face. Just screw up the face as much as you can now. Hold it. And relax. Now let's try that again. Hold it. Hold it. And relax. It's also good for the neck and shoulders. Just tighten up that whole area now. Hold it. And relax slowly. Let's try that again. Tighten up the whole area. Neck and shoulders. Hold it. And just relax slowly.

A third technique is best for tensions felt in the chest, though it has an effect on the whole body. Controlled breathing. Take a slow, deep in-breath, fill the lungs to capacity, hold for as long as comfortable, and just let the whole ribcage fall quickly, expelling all the air. Then wait for the next breath to arise naturally, and this will prevent hyperventilation. So now let's take in a deep breath, hold it, and just let it go. Let's try that again. Take a deep breath. Hold it. And just let it go.

Hopefully you will have developed a deep relaxation. So now we should find ourselves in a posture highly conducive for meditation. The spine should be energised but not tense. The rest of the body should feel relaxed, hanging, as it were, off this central column of the spine. And the head should be gently poised on top, symbolising the balance between physical alertness and relaxation.

So now, for a few moments, let's feel this posture as a whole, and recognise its qualities of alert energy and yet calm relaxation.

Now we need to develop the same sense of energetic alertness and relaxed calmness in the mind, and to achieve this we use the breath. Place your attention on the abdomen and feel its rising and falling motion as you breathe naturally. Please note this is not a breathing technique. The breath should not be interfered with.

Now it may be that the breath is not obvious to you at the abdomen, in which case see if you can feel it at the chest, rising and falling. The breath at the nostrils may also be used, but for the Mahāsi technique it is preferable to use the abdomen. See now which one is most obvious to you.

Now whichever place you've chosen, this is your primary object of meditation. This means you will use this place to establish an alert and calm awareness. If you move from one place to another, say from the nose to the abdomen, this will undermine your ability to become concentrated, that is, the ability to watch with an alert but calm attention without flitting away.

If you're watching the breath process at the abdomen or chest, observe the movement, the rising and falling, and use a noting word to still the thinking process. With the in-breath, note rising, rising, and with the out-breath, note falling, falling. After the out-breath, there's a rest, and there's danger that the mind will run away on fantasies. Now, to stop this happening, we choose a touch point. It may be the feeling of your hands on your lap, or the feelings of your legs on the floor. Choose what is most obvious.

So as you feel the abdomen or chest rising with the in-breath, feel those feelings, watch them closely and point your attention directly at them, noting, rising, rising. In the same way as you feel the abdomen or chest falling with the out-breath, feel the feelings, the sensations of the movement. Watch them intently and note falling, falling. If there's a pause before the in-breath, note a touching point. Touching, touching, touching. Now be sure as soon as the in-breath starts to return immediately to the abdomen or the chest.

If you're concentrating at the nostrils, it's the same, except it's more appropriate to use the noting words in-in, out-out, while remembering to concentrate on the sensations at the nostrils or the upper lip, wherever the passage of air is felt most acutely.

Please note it doesn't matter how many times you say the noting word. Once may be enough. What is important is to be attentive to the feelings or sensations as they arise. The word itself is of little importance. It's just a simple and very effective way to stop the mind from wandering. What you must pay attention to are all the sensations caused by the process of breathing.

Now you may find that your mind wanders off on thoughts and fantasies. When you wake up out of them, just note thinking, thinking, or dreaming, dreaming, once or twice, and then quickly and firmly go back to watching the sensations of breathing. But

you mustn't be rough or forceful. Training the mind is a bit like training a puppy dog to sit. When it gets up, you have to pat it down kindly but firmly. If you get angry and hit it, it will just want to run away.

So now, let's practice this breathing meditation for a while, observing and noting all the sensations. Rising... Falling, touching. If your mind is wandering, note what it's doing, dreaming, thinking, worrying, and so on, and bring it back gently but firmly to the breath. If you feel sleepy, put more energy into the spine, sit tall, but not tense. This part of the meditation is mainly concerned with establishing concentration. It's normal to spend a good ten minutes doing this until the mind becomes fairly still, at least until gross restlessness has gone, and you can watch the object, in this case the breath, fairly constantly.

We use the breath because it's a neutral feeling, it doesn't excite or depress us. So the mind becomes still and moves to a point of concentration by way of calm and peacefulness. This is different from the sort of concentration we get when we are doing something engrossing, such as watching a film, or having to do a job carefully. That depends upon stimulation, but the concentration we need for insight must arise out of a quiet and still mind.

And when this sort of concentrated, quiet mind is established, we find another faculty becomes prominent, our intuitive intelligence, *paññā*. Sometimes, when you're trying to listen to shortwave radio, there's so much interference, it's hard to hear exactly what's being said. Once the fuzz goes, everything becomes clear. So it is with *paññā*, our intuitive intelligence. Once the heart is calm and concentrated, and thinking and imagining has stopped, the intuitive intelligence is able to see and understand clearly what's going on.

So now, what we have to do is establish this concentrated attentiveness, alive with intelligence, *satipaññā*, not just on the breath, but on anything that comes into our field of awareness. The example I like is that of a bird watcher. They sit in a so-called hide. They hide there, hidden from the birds they are watching. In this way, the birds are not disturbed, and their natural habits can be observed. All the knowledge, such as of feeding, nesting, mating, and so on, comes by just observing, merely watching. In this way, this ability to be simply observers, interested to discover the true nature of our body, mind, and heart, is the key to spiritual insight.

But this watching, please understand clearly, is not a searching for something. We are not looking for something. We're just non-interfering observers, just looking at whatever comes into our field of awareness, just watching whatever arises right here and now, while it's happening, without any thoughts about it or questions.

So we begin by establishing attentiveness on the breath. Should a sound be heard, we avert to it immediately, noting hearing, hearing. Now, try to catch the quality of the sound at the very eardrum. In this way, we'll stop the mind flying out, as it were, to the object, such as a chirping bird or passing car, and set up a whole train of imaginative thoughts. The same with smell. Note it as smelling, smelling, right there in the nostrils. And again with any sensations on the body, such as itching and prickling, just note itching, itching, prickling, prickling, right there, where the sensations are felt, and plunge your attention into them.

Then there are feelings that arise in the body, such as heat and cold, heaviness and lightness, all sorts of discomforts and pleasures. A particular word, such as heat or cold, can be used where appropriate, otherwise a general word, feeling, can be used. Now, it's important we don't react to these feelings unless they are too severe to tolerate, for to react to them will lead us into restlessness. And do remember the noting word is a technique we use to keep the attention steady on the object. In other words, it controls the thinking faculty, but the attention itself should bury itself into the actual sensations.

Again, there are feelings in the body arising from moods and emotions. Dislikable ones, such as fear and depression, and likeable ones such as joy and love. We can use specific words here, such as love, guilt, and so on, but all the time feeling fully the mood or emotion, the actual feelings wherever they occur, such as in the chest or stomach.

Finally, there are thoughts and images. Note these as thinking or imagining, and they will stop. Otherwise, they will carry you off onto a daydream, sometimes for the whole of the meditation period.

And be especially aware of the judging mind. That's terrible, that's good, that's bad, that's nice, and so on. Don't correct or interfere with such thoughts. Just acknowledge them and note judging, judging. We're not trying to become spectators, getting involved in all the mental play, supporting this against that. We must take the position of an observer, an objective observer, just allowing all the play to unfold right there before our very gaze.

All the time we're trying to maintain that separation, that distance, that detachment from what's going on in the body, mind and heart. We observe all these psychophysical events as something other, as if belonging to someone else. In this way we can investigate objectively. So whatever is offered, a sensation, a feeling, a thought, just watch it carefully.

So now, let's sit tall, and with keen interest, let's watch the flow of physical and mental phenomena. Begin always with the breath. Rising, falling, touching. If the mind is wandering, note what it's doing, dreaming, thinking, worrying, and so on, and bring it back to the breath, firmly but gently. If there's sloth, energise the spine, re-establish the posture, slowly, very slowly, or you may disturb your concentration, noting the whole movement, straightening, straightening.

Sometimes there's a lot of pain, aching and tension comes up in the body. This won't be due to posture so long as the posture is correct. They'll probably be caused by unresolved emotions and mental states that have until now been suppressed out of consciousness. It's important to relax around them and develop an attitude of interest. Such discomfort, sometimes severe, may continue throughout a whole sitting or for many sittings until it resolves itself, and it may be that the underlying reason, such as an emotion, will not manifest itself. Just the passing of the discomfort will mean that the curing has taken place.

We need to develop patience to bear this sort of thing and use the opportunity to see pain as pain, just sensations, and to separate out the suffering which is the aversion or fear we feel towards them. We make both sides, the painful sensations and the mental attitudes, objects to be noted, observed, and understood.

So, keep noting, keep observing, maintaining a sharp attentiveness. If you get lost, start again with the breath, your home base and anchor. Always begin again with the breath. Rising, falling, touching. If your mind is wandering, bring it back firmly but gently to the primary object of our meditation, the breath. If there's tiredness or dullness, raise energy up the spine by sitting tall, though not tense, remember. Be especially aware of tension around the shoulders, neck and jaw.

Here we are sitting within ourselves, as it were, watching the inner films. The body, mind and heart display themselves just as they want. We don't interfere. It's a natural process of revelation. In time, many things may arise out of the subconscious which have long been suppressed. They'll reveal themselves when the time is right and the time is right when we'll be ready to accept them. In this way, insight meditation brings about a psychotherapy. Even painful traumatic memories from childhood will be eventually cleared out of the system, and with them all the neuroses and tensions they've caused. All we have to do to attain this purification of the heart is to remain steadfast at our observation post.

Now, although the cleansing of our psychology will happen naturally, it's not the aim of our meditation. The aim of our practice is to go to the deepest levels to see why suffering arises in the first place. One way is to note the relationship we have to whatever

is being observed. The mind constantly jumps from liking to disliking wanting what it likes not wanting what it dislikes. This sort of involvement is simply a way in which we try to find happiness in pleasurable states and escape unhappiness by running away from unpleasurable states.

This constant oscillation, this ricocheting from greed to aversion and back to greed, this is what the Buddha taught as the cause of our suffering in the Second Noble Truth. So, as pleasurable or unpleasurable objects arise, we must keenly note this secondary reaction of grabbing at them or pushing them away, sometimes turning away in fear, the twin of aversion. In this way, this reaction will cool down and even stop, and we shall experience a deeply satisfying equanimous mind. And this in turn will allow us to investigate deeper into the causes of suffering.

So let all that pain and pleasure surface and express itself. Watch the reaction, the grabbing, the aversion, the fear. Begin again with the breath. Rising, falling, touching. If your mind is wandering, note what it's been doing and re-establish your concentration on the breath. If you're sleepy, sit tall and raise energy up the spine.

As we begin to deepen our awareness of all the phenomena arising in our body, mind and heart, we'll become increasingly aware of what the Buddha called the three characteristics of existence. The first is the fact of transience. Everything is arising only to pass away. The second is the difficult teaching of non-self. As we watch all these mental and physical phenomena, we'll notice they arise of themselves. There's no one controlling them. They have their own life, their own energy.

At times the body, mind and heart may seem distant, something other. Before we talked of my sensations, my thoughts, my emotions, but now we find ourselves pointing at them, as it were, through the noting technique. There's a sensation, there's a thought, there's a feeling. We're slowly moving away from a relationship of identity and possession. I am my seeing, I am what I think, I am what I feel. I have a body, I have a mind, I have a heart. Instead, we're moving towards a position of detachment. This is the beginning of the experience of non-self. We discover that the psychophysical organism we call me doesn't constitute anything substantial. It's just made up of many parts that work in unison, just like a car. But there's no core to it, no substance.

Thirdly, as we've noticed, whenever we do fall into a relationship of attachment, desire or aversion to the body, mind and heart, of identifying and possessing, suffering follows.

This is the third characteristic of unsatisfactoriness. We should develop an attitude towards the body, mind and heart as one who rents a house, not as one who owns one.

It is the observation of these three characteristics of transience, insubstantiality and unsatisfactoriness that brings about the spiritual insights that release consciousness from its delusions and leads to liberation from all suffering. And it is this practice of *vipassanā* which is the tool we use. This bare attentiveness, simply observing all that arises and passes away, this choiceless awareness that does not control or manipulate, this impartial watchfulness that does not question or judge, this intuitive introspection, fully experiencing each mental and bodily phenomenon as it really is, this is the faculty of intuitive awareness, *satipaṇṇā*, the very faculty that will eventually bring the realisation of *Nibbāna*, the unborn, the unbecome, the unmade, the unconditioned.

All we have to do is watch, just observe, whatever arises as it arises and passes away. So let's begin again with the breath. Rising, falling, touching.

During daily life, to sit like this even for a few moments, long enough to re-establish a calm and alert attentiveness, will stop our emotions from snowballing. It will undermine the causes of stress. Just fifteen seconds may be enough to re-establish our centre. With practice, this can become a regular state of mind, instead of something that comes only under special conditions.

This calm heart and alert mind is the state we ought to be in all the time, even under stress. It is within this inner environment that this intuitive awareness, *satipaṇṇā*, can operate. Otherwise it becomes lost, drowned and controlled by runaway thoughts and emotions. Constantly make the effort to regain and maintain this inner posture. This is to live fully consciously.

And in this way, the practice of *vipassanā*, insight meditation, will seep into every moment of our lives, and we will be rewarded with great benefits.

Now, when we come to the end of a meditation period, it's best not to just jump out of it, but come out slowly. First, opening the eyes and taking in the light, and gently swaying from side to side. Then, rising slowly and mindfully, and in this way our intuitive mindfulness, *satipaṇṇā*, will be maintained.

May you be well, may you be happy, may you soon be liberated of all your suffering, may you experience the peace and bliss of *Nibbāna*.

## 45 Minute Assisted Meditation

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 41 min

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*This 45-minute guided meditation provides structured instruction in the Mahasi Sayadaw tradition of Vipassanā insight meditation. Bhante Bodhidhamma begins with establishing proper posture and body relaxation, then guides practitioners through breath awareness using the traditional 'rising, falling, sitting' noting technique.*

*The session progresses from concentrated attention on breathing sensations to the broader practice of open awareness, where practitioners learn to note and observe all arising phenomena - bodily sensations, sounds, emotions, and mental formations - as they appear and dissolve. The guidance emphasizes the natural recognition of the three characteristics of existence (anicca, dukkha, anattā) through direct observation rather than intellectual analysis.*

*With bell signals approximately every five minutes and a double bell at the halfway point, this meditation teaches the essential skill of returning attention to the breath whenever the mind wanders. The instruction concludes with encouragement to extend practice sessions and incorporate mettā bhāvanā (loving-kindness meditation) into daily routine. Perfect for developing consistent sitting practice and understanding the fundamental mechanics of insight meditation.*

A guided meditation.

A bell will ring approximately every five minutes and twice after half an hour should you wish to end your meditation then.

So, let us establish the posture. Lift up the spine. Remember the puppet string. Energise but not tense. And everything else relaxed off the central column. And the head poised gently on top.

Hands on our laps. Now let's just spend a few moments relaxing first by a mental volition telling all muscles to relax, then by tensing and releasing them, and finally by deep breathing. Whatever you feel is necessary to establish calmness in the body.

Now, let us acknowledge just noting and observing the feeling of the whole body. Sitting, sitting, sitting.



Now let us develop the same qualities of alertness and relaxation in the mind using our breath. Note and observe the sensation caused by the process of breathing at your preferred place. If the mind wanders, just bring it back gently but firmly to the breath. Rising, falling, sitting.

If your mind is wandering, note thinking or dreaming and bring your attention back to the breath, gently but firmly. If you feel sleepy, put more energy into the spine. Sit tall but not tense.

By now we should feel more focused and still, so let's open up the awareness and be attentive to whatever comes into the body, mind and heart. Note and observe carefully any sensations arising at the sense faculties, such as hearing a sound. Note and observe all sensations in the body: cold and heat, itching, stiffness and so on. Note and observe all emotional states as and when they occur. Note and catch all thoughts and images before they lead you astray, and if judging starts up, note it quickly.

Don't be concerned to see the three characteristics of existence: transience, unsatisfactoriness and insubstantiality. The intuitive intelligence, *satipaṇṇā*, once unlocked from the body, mind and heart, will see these three signs naturally. If any thought about them occurs, note thinking-thinking. Thought doesn't have the power to make spiritual insight.

So let's just note and observe each physical, mental and emotional event as it arises and passes away. No need to think about anything, no need to experience something extraordinary. Just ordinary consciousness and ordinary sensations, thoughts and emotions will do.

Always begin with the breath. And if we get lost, start again right there. Rising, falling, sitting.

If your mind is wandering, just bring it back gently but firmly to the process of breathing. If you feel sleepy, sit tall and raise energy up the spine. Don't be concerned by how many times we've wandered away and have had to re-establish our attentiveness. This is the practice, this is the training of the mind we must do persistently and patiently, raising interest to see exactly what's happening at the physical, emotional and mental levels.

We keep using the noting technique to tether the mind to all events as they arise and pass away. And if we get lost, we always start again with the breath.

Once you feel confident, try to meditate without the tape and lengthen your time to a good hour once in the morning and once in the evening. Don't forget to practice a little loving kindness meditation, *mettā bhāvanā*.

And when you end the sitting, come out slowly and gently and take that satipaṇṇā, your intuitive awareness, with you into ordinary daily life.

May your practice bear great fruit. May you be liberated of all suffering. May you experience the peace and bliss of Nibbāna.

## 30 Minute Bodycare Meditation

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 29 min

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*This guided meditation by Bhante Bodhidhamma transforms our relationship with the body through the practice of mettā (loving-kindness). Drawing upon the Buddha's own teachings, the session begins by examining our unhealthy attachments to the body - our aversion to what we find disgusting, our vanity about appearance, and our clinging to sensual pleasures. The meditation incorporates the three contemplations that inspired the Buddha's spiritual quest: recognizing the body's susceptibility to sickness, aging, and death.*

*After undermining wrong relationship patterns, Bhante guides us toward appreciation of this precious human birth. We apologize to our body for past mistreatment and systematically offer loving-kindness blessings from head to toe. The practice concludes with a visualization adapted from Tibetan Medicine Buddha tradition, drawing golden healing light through the body, before extending mettā to all beings everywhere.*

*This meditation beautifully integrates classical Buddhist body contemplation with practical healing visualization, making it accessible for both newcomers to mettā practice and experienced meditators seeking to deepen their relationship with embodied spiritual life. Perfect for anyone struggling with body image, chronic illness, or simply wishing to cultivate greater appreciation for this temporary but precious vessel.*

Body care. Offering *mettā*, goodwill, loving-kindness to the body. Remember you can stop the tape any time to develop a particular section.

First we need to undermine the wrong relationship we have to the body. We think it to be me or mine. As we weaken this identity and possession, so we can develop a more wholesome, skillful relationship.

Working first with possession. We hold on to what we like, we discard, we don't look at what we dislike. Bringing to mind a part of the body that disgusts us to some extent, here's some of the Buddha's own list. Feces, bile, pus, blood, sweat, fat, urine. Choose something, something to get in touch with, to feel that disgust. Now change your perspective and see it from a biological point of view. Perhaps your feelings are changing to equanimity, even interest.

Now take a part of the body you dislike because it's ugly. Too thin, too fat, too long, too short, so on. Again, get in touch with that feeling of dislike. Beauty and ugliness come from the judgmental mind. Can't things be just okay as they are? See if you can turn towards those parts with the heart of acceptance.

Finally, there are those parts that bring us great pleasure. Take any of the five senses, for instance. Consider now suffering from an impairment or loss of one of them, say hearing or sight. As we know from people with disabilities, it doesn't mean we couldn't live equally fulfilling lives. So we can see that such suffering comes from attachment.

Now let us work a little with the delusion of identity. Here we can use the three contemplations that awoke the Buddha-to-be to his search for the end of suffering. Repeating each phrase in the heart and accepting its truth value.

First, to undermine our obsession and intoxication with health. This body is subject to disease. This body is of a nature to fall ill. This body has not gone beyond sickness.

Now to undermine our obsession and intoxication with youthfulness. This body is subject to aging. This body has not gone beyond aging. This body is now in a process of aging.

And now to undermine our obsession and intoxication with life itself. This body is subject to death. This body has not gone beyond death. This body will die.

Having undermined to some extent the wrong relationship we have to the body, we can now develop a right relationship. The Buddha said this was a precious rebirth. Here we experience joy and woe and we have the intelligence to rise above them. Firstly, we can't be here without a body. It's as simple as that. Secondly, it's through the senses that we experience the world and learn. Thirdly, it's through the body we relate, communicate and express ourselves. And finally, in this tradition, it's through the very breath of the body that we can develop the spiritual faculties.

Once we realise how precious the body really is, we can't but want to care for it. Now, we haven't done so in the past, so before we can offer it, loving kindness, let us apologise for all the rough times we've given it and perhaps are still giving it. Whatever harm I have done to you in thought, word and deed, by way of greed, hatred and delusion, intentionally or unintentionally, I'm heartily sorry for it, and I determine from this day on to treat you with due care and respect.

So now we can begin to offer our blessings to the body. Choose a phrase which expresses for you healing or well-being. Place it in the heart and offer that blessing to the whole body. Now it may be that you see light or feel heat, all well and good, but there's no need for such manifestations. What is working for us is our acts of will, our intentions.

So now let's take our time and go through the whole body from the top of the head to the tip of the toes. Starting at the hair and scalp, offer your blessings there. Come down into the brain and fill it with loving-kindness. Bless your eyes and your ears. Bless your nose and nasal cavities. Bless your mouth with its tongue, teeth, lips. The jaw. Pour your blessing into your throat, the precious voice box, so that the whole head feels warmed and energised. May you be free of sickness and disease. May you be well and strong.

Turning our attention now to the top of the spine and make your way down, offering each vertebrae your blessing. Come down the neck, down the back, down the small of the back, down to the very tip so the whole spine feels warmed and energised. May you be free of sickness and disease. May you be well and strong.

Starting at the left shoulder, massage it with loving kindness. And make your way down towards the elbow, down towards the wrist, and into the hand. Massage your hand with warm loving kindness. So the whole arm feels warmed and energised. May you be free of sickness and disease. May you be well and strong.

Moving to the right shoulder. Again, massage it with loving kindness. Making our way down to the elbow, down to the wrist, and into the hand. Massage your hand with warm, loving kindness. So the whole arm feels warmed and energised. May you be free of sickness and disease. May you be well and strong.

Turning our attention now to the chest area. Now you can either offer your blessings to particular organs or you can just fill that felt space with loving-kindness. So the whole chest feels warmed and energised. May you be free of sickness and disease. May you be well and strong.

Moving down to the midriff, the stomach area. Again, fill that area with warm, loving kindness. So the whole area feels warmed and energised. May you be free of sickness and disease. May you be well and strong.

Moving down into the abdomen with all its varied systems. Offer your blessings there. Fill that area with warm, loving kindness. Though the whole area feels warmed and energised, may you be free of sickness and disease. May you be well and strong.

Moving to the left hip. Massage it with loving-kindness, making our way down to the knee and down to the ankle and down to the foot. Massage your foot with warm, loving kindness. So the whole leg feels warmed and energised. May you be free of sickness and disease. May you be well and strong.

Moving to the right hip. Offer your blessing there. And making your way down to the knee, and down to the ankle, and into the foot. Massage your foot with warm loving kindness. So the whole leg feels warmed and energised. May you be free of sickness and disease. May you be well and strong.

So now we fill the whole body with warm blessings. Now perhaps there's a part of the body that needs special attention. Go there now and spend a while filling that area with goodwill, loving-kindness.

So now it's time to open ourselves up to whatever source of energy there is in the universe, using a method taken from the Tibetan tradition of the Medicine Buddha. Imagine there's a golden light descending upon you from above. Remember, any color will do, which you feel is healing or energising. And as it pours down, it begins to form a ball just above your head. Don't worry if the image is not strong. Let it pour down until the ball takes on the feel of warm water, the consistency of warm water, and it slowly begins to rotate on itself.

Still pouring down from above, the ball gets heavier, and we can begin to feel it upon our scalps. Let it slowly descend down through the scalp, gently rotating, feeling it over the forehead and the back of the head, descending into the brain, filling it with that warm, vibrant energy. Feel it enter into our eyes, and ears. Feel its energy and warmth entering into your nose and nasal cavities. Slowly, gently rotating. Still pouring down from above. And we can feel its energy now entering into our mouths. Filling our mouths with its warm golden energy. Down into the jaw. Still pouring in from above, the ball gently rotating. And we can feel its warm, golden, vibrant energy filling our throats. The whole head is now this golden ball, gently rotating, full of energy, warmth.

Still pouring down from above, we can feel it beginning to spread over our shoulders and continuing to rotate, gently sinking into our chest, deep into our arms, deep into our chests, filling that whole area with warm golden delight. And it's still pouring down from above, down through the head, down the throat, into this ball gently rotating around our chest.

And it continues downward, filling the rest of our arms, down to the elbows, filling that whole midriff, the stomach, that whole area, filling it with this warm golden delight. Still pouring down from above, down through the head, down the arms, down the throat, down the chest, into this ball, gently rotating around our stomach.

And it continues to go downwards, gently turning, filling the whole abdomen with its warm, golden delight. Still pouring down from above, down through the head, down the throat, down the arms, down the chest, through the stomach into this ball, gently rotating around the abdomen.

And we feel it descending, filling our hands, filling our hips, gently filling those areas with warm, vibrant, golden energy, spiralling downwards, slowly. We can feel it entering our knees, downwards until we can feel it around our feet. Filling our feet with its warm golden energy. Still pouring in from above. Down through the head, down the throat, down the arms, down through the chest, through the stomach, into the abdomen, down through the hips and legs, into this ball, gently rotating around our feet.

So now we can use this energy. With the in-breath, draw that energy, with our own energy, up the spine to the top of the head. And there, let it join with all that energy still pouring down from above. And with the out-breath, let it all cascade down the body. Just breathing in and up, breathing out and down. Just breathing in and breathing out. And if there's a part of the body that needs special attention, let it pass through that part like water through a sponge.

So now we can share this energy with individuals by bringing people to mind and offering them our blessings.

And finally, we can offer our blessings to all beings in all directions. Just breathing in, into the heart and breathing out to all beings. May all beings be free of physical pain. May all beings be free of mental distress. May all beings be liberated of all their suffering. May all beings be well and strong. May all beings treat their bodies wisely. May all beings strive diligently for their liberation. May all beings experience the peace and bliss of Nibbāna.

*Sābe satā sukītā hantu Sābe satā sukītā hantu Sābe satā sukītā hantu.*

# Investigative Eating

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 12 min

*In this guided meditation, Bhante Bodhidhamma explores the practice of investigative eating as a path to understanding pleasure without attachment. Drawing on the Buddha's teachings on yoniso manasikāra (right attention), he guides practitioners through a detailed examination of the eating process, from the initial intention to eat through the final moments of reflection.*

*The talk emphasizes approaching food as medicine for the body rather than seeking ultimate happiness through sensory pleasure. Bhante Bodhidhamma breaks down the eating experience into its component parts: bodily sensations at the tongue, emotional responses in the heart, mental attention, and the will or intention behind our actions. This deconstruction helps practitioners understand the difference between gratification (which leads to continued craving) and contentment (the mind without desire).*

*Practical guidance includes maintaining close attention to sense bases, using simple noting like 'tasting' rather than conceptual labels, and recognizing the body's natural signals for satiation. The meditation concludes with instruction on quiet abiding after meals, cultivating the three factors leading to awakening: calmness of body and heart, steadiness of attention, and receptive awareness that allows insights to arise naturally.*

So now it's time to eat again. And just to spend a bit more time reflecting on this process.

So remember that we have to find a way of being with pleasure and the joys of life in a way that it doesn't have this aftermath, this comeback. Frustration when you can't get it, grief when you lose it, and take out insurance just in case you do. All that is underneath. While we're enjoying stuff, it's not a problem. Nothing like it.

So, food or eating, which we have to do every day, is just the opportunity to remind ourselves about how to be with pleasure in a non-attached, non-indulgent way.

The beginning is to get the right attitude. So if there's an attitude in the mind which is going to really enjoy this food, then there's going to be a danger that it's indulging it. And what we mean by that is that we're seeking happiness in food. Real happiness, lasting happiness. It's momentary, but it doesn't deliver the ultimate that we're looking for.



So, you have to put the right intention into the mind, which is to nourish the body. Food is just medicine for the body. And I do a chanting, it's more formal this lunchtime, I receive the food and then I do a chant which basically says that I'm not eating food in order to escape my problems or to add to them or to get for the pleasure of it, I'm just eating the food for the purpose of keeping the body healthy so that I can live the spiritual life.

So that's important to actually when you take your food and you sit in front of it you remind yourself so there's your attitude and this leaves you free to investigate the process around the whole action of eating so as you make your intention to eat you see and you pick up your fork or whatever you see.

You know, really begin right at the beginning by contacting the body. So how does the metal feel? Begin right there at the sense of touch. And then as you scoop it and put it into your mouth, just that first delightful explosion on the tongue, you see. Just stay there right with it. Keep the attention right on the tongue.

And if you use a word like tasting rather than curry or whatever, then it keeps you attentive to the process that's happening. And we're just trying to find out what taste is before it fits into some conceptual pattern. That's another problem we have, that we keep looking at things from history. We keep looking at things from a past experience. So we need to get back to a very original mind, which is a direct experience of things. And it's not that difficult to develop. It's just a case of keeping the attention very close to the sense base.

So while you're tasting, tasting, tasting, you see, your attention is right there on what's happening at the tongue, what it's doing, how you're chewing. You're just there with the mechanics of it. And you're aware of the pleasure. That's the point. You're aware of the pleasure. The pleasure is pleasurable, right? You don't have to say to yourself, this is pleasurable taste, but it's most unpleasurable. It's pleasurable taste. It's a total openness to it, a receiving of what that sense base is giving you.

And it may be that after some time, after you've swallowed the first, you can just stop for a moment and just recognize what's happened within the heart, the emotional base. Hopefully, it is now in a state of delight. And to feel that, to get into the feel of it so that you know, well, this is also a form of energy, a form of energy, but it's not the same as the gross physical energy. And it's making that distinction, deconstructing our experience, which begins to undermine this idea of who I am.

So by disconnecting, as it were, the body with its sense space, with its sensations, and the heart with its more subtle emotional feelings, we're beginning to deconstruct the event, you see.

Then as you, before the next bite or sometime, just to hold on for a minute and just to feel that intention to eat. Make it very obvious to yourself. So that intention is coming from a natural base, it's just appetite, the body wanting some nourishment. But there's also, remember, behind it, this seeking for desire, this seeking for happiness. Just stay with it, feel it. Is that an emotion? What is it? What is that force that drives us to eat? What is it? And it's not a case of an intellectual answer. It's a case of a direct experience of it.

Normally speaking, all this is just one thing, isn't it? You know, you go into a restaurant and eat a pizza. That's it. It's like it's one experience. But here we're trying to deconstruct the event, you see. It's the same with the cinema. You go in the cinema or watching a VD, it's one experience. You hear and you're seeing and you're empathizing. You're doing all things all in that one moment. But actually there's a whole load of processes going on, you know. The hearing isn't the seeing and the seeing isn't the empathizing, see. So it's really just trying to investigate this.

And remember our purpose is to get to the end of suffering, or to put it more positively, is to be happy, right? We're trying to get to a decent happiness, that's what we're trying to get to. So this process isn't just a nice little exercise we're doing, we're actually trying to get to a point where we're happy, heaven's sake.

So, we've made these three distinctions now, there's the body, there's the heart with its, of course we've got the mind, the mind's, you know, we're using the mind to keep the attention steady, so it's down to one word, so it's not thinking about anything. See, that's our greatest hindrance, to think about something. And then we've got this process of the will, right? The will, intention.

And hopefully there'll come a part of the meal where you get this feedback from the body saying enough. And it's hanging on there with that and just feeling the override and just knowing that that's the old greed. Now, normally speaking what we would do is just keep eating till even the greed was satisfied. That's when the body signals back that it's getting sick. And at that point you might say it's a point of gratification. So we feel gratified, and we have a little rest period, and then the old desire rises again.

However, if we stay with the desire and not feed it, we put our attention just on the desire, that wanting, wanting, and just wait for that to fade out, we get to something which feels like gratification, but it's better called contentment, because this is the mind

without desire. Now to know the distinction between being gratified and being contented is crucial. Because one leads you towards liberation and the other one towards hell. So it's worth making that distinction.

Now it may be that you've taken a little too much food and you've got this food left and your body's telling you actually you've had enough. So now you've got a choice. You can either stuff it into your body knowing it's not going to do the body any good or throw it away and feel guilty. Because all these people, especially these days, are having a shortage of food in some areas.

So now, what I would suggest you do is that you throw it away and feel guilty. And the reason for that is that as you contact your guilt and really feel it, you see, that then becomes your guardian. Because the next time you approach food, you'll say to yourself, now I don't want to feel that guilt again. That's horrible. So you take a little less and there's always a chance of getting some more food afterwards. Yeah? So, even though that's not PC, that's what I would suggest you do. And feel the guilt.

Then, when it comes to the end of the meal, you see, just stop for a minute and just recollect. What was it you've experienced? This recollection is important because it makes you revisit those places, you see. And by doing that, it becomes a habit in the mind, a moment of reflection. It's one of the things the Buddha constantly goes on about. *Yoniso manasikāra*, it means right attention, right reflection, to think about things properly.

Now, after the meal, there's a little break there, and what is good to practice there is this quiet abiding. So there's these three factors that lead to enlightenment. The calmness, calmness of the body, calmness of the heart. Even if you feel agitated or the heart's very troubled or whatever, you can still, as it were, take it for a walk. Just relax around it. Steadiness of attention that's always there so you have to keep the noting going or else the mind will just wander and this attitude of just receiving just receiving not doing anything about anything and just dropping for a while the inquiry, the inquiry.

As an actual intention, you'd be surprised that in those receptive moments insights arise naturally, because although we make a distinction between awareness and this intuitive intelligence, they're two sides of the same coin. One is passive, receiving, and one is active in insight. So it's the same, you know, when something goes wrong, I don't know, you can't find something or something goes wrong with your car or something, you open the bonnet, see, first you look. Look, that's the receiving. And then you see, the

engine's gone. It's like there's always that listening and then understanding, hearing and then listening, understanding. So there's always this flick from the passive to the active.

So after lunch, if you want to take a walk around the paddock or whatever, then just practice that. You can practice walking up and down in meditation, but with the attitude of just relaxing into the present moment, wide awake. And then, by all means, feel free to take a rest.

## Why Chant

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 3 min

*In this instructional talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma explores the role of chanting and ritual in establishing a meditation practice. He explains how simple ceremonies—bowing, lighting candles and incense, and reciting traditional formulas—can help set the proper tone and intention for practice, though emphasizes these are not strictly necessary.*

*The talk provides detailed pronunciation guidance for essential Pāli chants, including the threefold recitation of taking refuge in the Buddha, Dhamma, and Saṅgha (Buddhaṃ saraṇaṃ gacchāmi), and the five training rules (pañca-sīla). Bhante carefully explains the meaning of each precept: refraining from harming living beings, taking what is not given, sexual misconduct, wrong speech, and intoxicants that cloud awareness.*

*The episode concludes with guidance on closing practice with gratitude and the traditional final bow, along with making a daily determination to cultivate Right Awareness with a caring heart. This practical instruction serves both newcomers learning these foundational elements and experienced practitioners seeking to deepen their understanding of Buddhist ritual and its psychological benefits for establishing mindful presence.*

Now as a daily practice, some like to start with a little ritual: bowing, lighting a candle and incense, and taking the refuges and training rules. Although this is not necessary, some small ceremony can set the tone. I have recorded the chant for bowing, taking the three refuges in the Buddha, *Dhamma*, and *Saṅgha*, and also the five training rules, should you want to take them before a sitting. There is also at the end a final bow.

This is how to pronounce the Pali, the language of the scriptures. When bowing, the end of the word is like our "ang" in "I rang the bell." It means "I bow to the Buddha, the Dhamma and the Saṅgha."

*Buddhaṃ saraṇaṃ gacchāmi*  
*Dhammaṃ saraṇaṃ gacchāmi*  
*Saṅghaṃ saraṇaṃ gacchāmi*  
*Dutiyampi Buddhaṃ saraṇaṃ gacchāmi*  
*Dutiyampi Dhammaṃ saraṇaṃ gacchāmi*  
*Dutiyampi Saṅghaṃ saraṇaṃ gacchāmi*

*Tatīyampi Buddhaṃ saraṇaṃ gacchāmi*  
*Tatīyampi Dhammaṃ saraṇaṃ gacchāmi*  
*Tatīyampi Saṅghaṃ saraṇaṃ gacchāmi*

I take refuge in the Buddha, the Dhamma and the Saṅgha. For the second time, I take refuge in the Buddha, Dhamma, Saṅgha. And for the third time, I take refuge in the Buddha, Dhamma and the Saṅgha.

The five training rules or precepts are pronounced like this:

*Pāṇātipātā veramaṇī sikkhāpadaṃ samādiyāmi*  
*Adinnādānā veramaṇī sikkhāpadaṃ samādiyāmi*  
*Kāmesumicchācārā veramaṇī sikkhāpadaṃ samādiyāmi*

And they are translated like this: not to harm any living beings, not to take what is not freely given, not to abuse our sexual powers, not to use wrong speech, not to take any drugs or drinks that tend to cloud the mind.

At the end of the session, it is customary to complete it with another three bows:

*Imāya dhamānudhammapaṭipattiyā*  
*Buddhaṃ pūjemi*  
*Dhammaṃ pūjemi*  
*Saṅghaṃ pūjemi*

By following the path of the Dhamma, the true law, I bow to the Buddha, the Dhamma and the Saṅgha.

And finally, before you rise, make a determination to devote this day, just this one day, to mindfulness with a caring heart.

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